

Chapter 21: The Answer He Wants

Jenny avoided him for exactly three hours.

It wasn't intentional at first.

It just... happened.

She stayed in the kitchen longer than usual.

She took extra orders.

She cleaned things that were already clean.

Anything to delay it.

Anything to avoid the moment waiting for her at table seven.

But Austin didn't move.

He stayed seated.

Patient.

Unchanging.

Like he had decided time itself would bend first.

Bao eventually caught up to her near the storage room.

"You're stalling," he said.

"I'm working."

"You're stalling emotionally."

Jenny shot him a look.

"Stop talking like that."

"You're going to answer him, aren't you?"

Jenny hesitated.

That hesitation was enough.

Bao nodded slowly.

"Yeah. You are."

"I didn't say anything."

"You didn't need to."

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"I don't even know what I'm supposed to say."

Bao tilted his head.

"Maybe the truth?"

Jenny laughed once.

Short.

Dry.

"That's funny."

But Bao didn't smile this time.

"Scary truth or safe lie?"

Jenny went quiet.

That was the real question.

And she hated it.

When she finally walked out, the restaurant felt too loud.

Too bright.

Too normal.

And there he was.

Still at table seven.

Still waiting.

Jenny stopped a few steps away.

Austin looked up immediately.

Like he had sensed her before seeing her.

Jenny swallowed.

Then walked closer.

Slow.

Controlled.

She placed the order pad down.

"I don't like this," she said.

Austin didn't react immediately.

He just studied her face.

"Which part?"

"All of it."

A pause.

Then softly—

"That's not an answer."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I didn't say I was answering."

Austin nodded slightly.

"Then why are you here?"

That question hit harder than it should have.

Jenny hesitated.

Then said quietly,

"Because you won't leave me alone until I do."

Austin leaned forward slightly.

"No."

Jenny frowned.

"No?"

"I wouldn't force an answer."

A beat.

Then—

"But I won't pretend I don't want one."

Silence.

Jenny looked at him.

Really looked this time.

Not as a customer.

Not as a problem.

As something else entirely.

Something that had slowly become unavoidable.

"You're serious," she said quietly.

"Yes."

That simplicity again.

No games.

No layers.

Just him.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"This is going to ruin things," she said.

Austin didn't look away.

"It already changed things."

Jenny shook her head.

"You don't understand what I lose if this goes wrong."

Austin's voice softened slightly.

"Then tell me what you would gain if it goes right."

That question...

Stuck.

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Nothing came out.

Because she didn't have a clean answer for that either.

Not one she trusted.

Austin noticed her silence.

He always did.

Jenny's voice dropped.

"You don't fit in my life."

A pause.

Then—

"Then change the life."

That made her look up sharply.

"...It's not that simple."

"I didn't say it was simple."

"You say things like it is."

"I don't think it is," he corrected quietly. "I think it's necessary."

Jenny stepped back slightly.

"You're talking like this is already decided."

Austin stood slowly.

Not aggressively.

Just... present.

"I'm talking like I'm not walking away from it anymore."

Silence.

The restaurant felt too far away again.

Too irrelevant.

Jenny felt her heart beat too loudly.

"Why me?" she asked quietly.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

For once.

He looked uncertain.

Not about the feeling.

But about the words.

Then he said softly,

"Because I don't feel like myself when you're not there."

That answer wasn't poetic.

Wasn't rehearsed.

It was raw.

Jenny froze.

Austin continued.

"And I don't want to go back to who I was before I met you."

Silence.

Jenny felt something inside her shift sharply.

Not falling.

Not rising.

Breaking a little.

She whispered,

"That's not fair."

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

A beat.

Then—

"But it's true."

Jenny looked away quickly.

Too quickly.

Her voice came out quieter than she intended.

"I can't just... give you an answer like this."

Austin didn't push.

He just said,

"I'm not asking for a perfect one."

Jenny swallowed.

"...Then what are you asking for?"

A pause.

Then softly—

"Honesty."

That word again.

Jenny closed her eyes for a moment.

Because honesty meant risk.

And risk meant everything she had been surviving for could shift.

She opened her eyes again.

Looked at him.

Really looked.

And for the first time...

She didn't run from the moment.

"I think..." she started.

Her voice shook slightly.

She stopped.

Took a breath.

Then continued.

"I think I feel it too."

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Austin didn't move.

Didn't speak.

Didn't react immediately.

Jenny's chest tightened instantly.

Regret.

Fear.

Everything at once.

"I don't know what it is," she added quickly. "But I feel it."

A beat.

Then Austin exhaled slowly.

Like he had been holding something in for a very long time.

Jenny braced herself.

But he didn't smile.

Didn't celebrate.

He just looked at her.

And said quietly,

"Good."

That simple word hit harder than anything else.

Jenny frowned slightly.

"Good?"

Austin nodded once.

"Yes."

A pause.

Then softer—

“Because now I don’t have to guess alone.”

Jenny didn’t respond.

She just stood there.

Feeling like something irreversible had just shifted between them.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But permanently.

And for the first time...

Neither of them stepped away.